Private Moiseenko, who was traveling on the dry cargo ship *Orenburg*, told his friends that "he had not taken an oath to serve Fidel Castro and was going to Cuba under duress." He argued that privates such as he had no reason to be afraid of Cuban "counterrevolutionaries," who were allegedly shooting only officers. Moiseenko—a Ukrainian, judging by his surname—probably had in mind popular rumors about the tactics employed by the Ukrainian nationalist underground after World War II. Andzor Somonodzharia, a recruit from Georgia, told his fellow soldiers that in 1956 Russian tanks had crushed the Georgian rebellion, killing old men, women, and children. He hated the Russians and was going to avenge the sufferings of his people. He was referring to riots in the Georgian capital of Tbilisi against Khrushchev's de-Stalinization policies: the protesters had indeed been dispersed by tanks.[16]

There were also nonpolitical discussions among the enlisted men that attracted KGB attention. Some suggested that Cuba was full of monkeys that attacked humans. Others predicted that the United States was going to declare a military blockade of the island. The KGB also picked up signs that as the trip went on, troop morale declined, and more of the men were becoming depressed. Some could not reconcile themselves to the fact that instead of being demobilized and sent home at the end of their three-year term they were being shipped off to Cuba. Others were exhausted by the heat between decks and debilitated by seasickness. Depressed soldiers told KGB informers that they were ready to jump into the sea and end their suffering.[17]

For the KGB, "jumping into the sea" presented a challenge. Those who were thinking of jumping ship might very well survive and reach a foreign shore or a foreign ship and "betray the motherland" by disclosing top-secret information about their units and the ship's cargo. Senior Lieutenant Sennikov, the KGB officer accompanying the *Orenburg*, instructed his informers to look for members of the crew and the military contemplating defection. That might happen when the ship was passing through the narrow waterways of the Black Sea straits, and Sennikov did his best to ensure that no defection would take place there. "During the passage of the Bosporus all passengers, including officers, were shut up in tweendeck 5, and a guard of CPSU members and agents was posted on the stern."[18]